

The International Forum
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LOGOTHERAPY
Journal of Search for Meaning

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THE INTERNATIONAL FORUM FOR LOGOTHERAPY is the official publication of the Viktor Frankl Institute of Logotherapy. It presents the meaning-oriented existential philosophy and therapy developed by Dr. Viktor Frankl and expanded by logotherapists throughout the world, working in counseling, education, medicine, nursing, psychology, social work, and other fields where the question of meaning becomes pertinent. The FORUM publishes experiential reports, theoretical papers, personal essays, quantitative, qualitative, and mixed methods research studies, practice and innovative logotherapeutic techniques for individuals and groups, and book and reviews. Case studies are not currently being published.

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Editors Introduction

Rodney B. Dieser Ph.D., CTRS, LMHC

This issue of the *International Forum for Logotherapy* was based on a call for papers related to music in logotherapy and logo-philosophy. I conceived this theme after reading Daniel Levitin's (2024) national bestseller, which explores how music serves as medicine. Dr. Levitin is an American Canadian neuroscientist, cognitive psychologist, musician, and the Founding Dean of Arts & Humanities at Minerva University in San Francisco, as well as the James McGill Professor Emeritus at McGill University in Montreal. In 2006, I read his New York Times bestselling book, *This Is Your Brain On Music*, and used this book as a required reading in a one-credit class I taught at the University of Northern Iowa that explored how Bruce Springsteen's music can increase moral development and wellness (the foundational thoughts of this class can be found in Dieser, 2014). In his most recent book, Levitin (2024) outlines that “Engaging with music, whether a listener or a player, facilitates entry into the brain’s Default Mode Network (DMN), a path to the subconscious that is instrumental to everything from problem solving to relaxation, from creativity to immune system function” (p. 5). He further outlines how music can evoke a sense of envisioning the future, including the discovery of meaning, and explains how music can serve as therapy for movement disorders, Parkinson’s disease, trauma, mental health issues, memory loss and stroke, pain, and neurodevelopmental disorders.

I also imagined this theme after reflecting on Viktor Frankl’s thoughts on music. As one example, in Frankl’s (2020) *Yes to Life in Spirit of Everything*, he states:

Imagine that you are sitting in a concert hall and listening to your favorite symphony, and your favorite bars of the symphony resound in your ears, and you are so moved by the music that it sends shivers down your spine; and now imagine that it would be possible (something that is psychologically so impossible) for someone to ask you in this moment whether your life has meaning. I believe you would agree with me if I declared that in this

case you would only be able to give one answer, and it would go something like: ‘It would have been worth it to have lived for this moment alone!’” (p. 38).

This issue of the *International Forum for Logotherapy* holds four articles. The first, by Barbara E. Ashton, is a double-blind, peer-reviewed article that examines the application of a logotherapy framework to music therapy practice. To this end, Barbara E Ashton outlines seven principles that can be used to successfully provide a logotherapy-centered music therapy intervention. The second article, which I wrote, is a personal narrative regarding how Bruce Springsteen’s music helped me as an adolescent/young man discover meaning when my mother was dying of terminal cancer some forty years ago. In this article, I suggest that much of the Springsteen music I listened to was built on a foundation of logo-philosophy, and this music helped me process death, suffering, hope, relationships, and self-transcendence before I ever heard of Viktor Frankl or logotherapy. The third article, written by Tanja M. Torvikoski in Finland, describes a logotherapeutic framework for teachers who are supporting next-generation music pedagogues amid today's systemic and cultural pressures of everyday life. Tanja M. Torvikoski posits that a logotherapy approach can (1) increase value- and purpose-oriented dialogue; (2) enhance knowledge and awareness regarding themes of values and purpose; (3) clarify the conceptual language connected to values and purpose; and (4) strengthen the ability to identify and interpret value orientations, supporting conscious, responsible, and stable life choices and actions. The last article, written by Marian Edmonds-Allen, can be found in the Logo-Philosophy Stories/Phenomenology section of the *International Forum for Logotherapy*. To remind the reader, articles in this section feature engaging stories that incorporate logotherapy principles throughout. This article tells the story of meaning in the moment when music and meaning merged in a church basement during a youth program focused on helping homeless youth.

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Double Blind Peer Review Article

A Meaning-Centered Lens for Music Therapy: A Theoretical Look at Applying Logotherapy to Music Therapy Practice

Barbara E. Ashton

Music therapists have an inherent understanding of the capacity for meaning making through music. Kenny (2006) says that "...music fulfills man's need for beauty and can satisfy his search for meaning in the world" (p. 63). Bruscia's Improvisation Assessment Profiles (1987) are based on universal constructs that apply to humans in every part of their lives. These constructs are used for assessing clients' musical improvisations and finding meaning in their themes (Zanders, 2025). In another example, Crowe (2017) describes how the music therapy client often experiences transpersonal content during music therapy (such as non-ordinary states of consciousness, powerful imagery, myths and archetypes, and intense emotional responses), and that this content is ripe material for interpreting meaning for the client. Because of music's capacity for meaning-making and meaningful experiences, logotherapy is a valuable lens for music therapy practice. Musical behavior, as a universal human phenomenon, naturally lends itself to developing meaning in a person's life (Hodges, 2020). Spanning the range of human experience from neurological, cognitive and motor benefits, introspection and social dynamics to emotional expression and spiritual transcendence (Bruscia, 2013; Crowe, 2017; Hodges, 2020; Rolvsjord, 2010), music therapists and music psychologists already recognize the great potential for discovering meaning through music. This paper posits a meaning-centered lens through which music therapists can view client progress. By using a meaning-centered lens, all music therapists, regardless of approach or training, can see the powerful impact that music therapy has on clients' ability to discover meaning in all aspects of their lives, particularly in their struggles.

A Brief Overview of Music Therapy

Music therapy is defined as "the clinical & evidence-based use of music interventions to accomplish individualized goals within a therapeutic relationship by a credentialed professional

who has completed an approved music therapy program” (AMTA, 2024). It is further conceptualized by the World Federation of Music Therapy (2023) as

The professional use of music and its elements as an intervention in medical, educational, and everyday environments with individuals, groups, families, or communities who seek to optimize their quality of life and improve their physical, social, communicative, emotional, intellectual, and spiritual health and wellbeing.

The World Federation additionally points out the importance of cultural, social, and political context on areas such as research, practice, education and clinical training of music therapists in various parts of the world. This is a relevant addition to a meaning-based exploration of music therapy because cultural, social, and political influences greatly impact the ways in which music creates meaning for individuals and groups (Crowe, 2017; Whitehead-Pleaux & Tan, 2017). Music therapists utilize four broad categories of music experience, including receptive (listening experiences), recreative (performing experiences), composition (songwriting experiences), and improvisation (spontaneous musical creation) (Bruscia, 2013; Polen, Shultis & Wheeler, 2017). Therapeutic musical behavior, or what music therapists often refer to as “musicking”, occurs as a dialogue. This dialogue may be with the self, with the therapist, with peers in the therapy group, with family members, or there may be multiple levels of dialogue occurring (Bruscia, 2013). Dialogue is also a key methodological component of logotherapy (Pattakos & Dunden, 2017). The word itself comes from two Greek words – dia (passing through) and logos (meaning or spirit). Musical dialoguing offers wonderful opportunities for clients to discover meaning as it “passes through” the music from one person to another (Bruscia, 2013; Kenny, 2006); or in the case of self-dialogue, from aspects of one’s unconscious or subconscious self to conscious awareness (Bonny, 2002; Crowe, 2017).

Theoretical Foundations

To explore a meaning-centered lens of music therapy, this paper will describe how music therapy promotes the discovery of meaning for clients by demonstrating how music addresses the key principles of Victor Frankl's logotherapy. According to Frankl, meaning can be discovered in 3 ways – by doing a deed (taking responsibility for oneself and one's actions and choices), by experiencing a value (love, culture, nature, art, justice, etc.), and by suffering (1962). While music therapists try to avoid causing additional suffering to their clients, we recognize that every client, indeed every human, has experienced suffering. Music therapists believe that the three-way relationship between the client, the music, and the therapist can act synergistically to help clients discover meaning in their suffering, their actions or deeds, and the experience of values (Bruscia, 2013). In music therapy, the focus is on musicking (the active “doing” or performance of musical behavior) and on experiencing various aspects of the music that can support client goals (value) (Bruscia, 1987; Bruscia, 2013). In doing musical behavior, a client must make choices, act, and take responsibility for their role (Polen, Shultis & Wheeler, 2017). Through the action of this musical “deed”, the client experiences various values that they can then choose to pursue or let go (Crowe, 2017). Once making this decision about values, the clients can reduce their suffering (Bruscia, 2013). For example, during a group re-creation of a pop song, the clients perform the musical behavior needed to re-create the song (singing, playing keyboard or drums). Through this experience, they encounter the value of aesthetics (whereby the music sounds good); the value of teamwork (where the clients must work together to create an aesthetically pleasing sound); and the value of dependability (where each client must be accountable for their own role in the music or the song will sound terrible). If any of these clients have experienced previous suffering related to these deeds and values, this music therapy experience – doing a deed and experiencing values – can provide a pathway for them to reduce their suffering going forward, and to have a different perspective on the suffering of their past.

In a 2000 interview with the Nordic Journal of Music Therapy, Bruscia suggests his own three interrelated sources for finding meaning in music therapy. The first source is meaning as *implicate order*, or shared reality. According to Bruscia, this “is the reality that is separate from our perception or construction of it, yet directly accessible to us through our consciousness. This implicated order is that meaning which is already (and always) there to be discovered; it does not need to be constructed: indeed, it cannot be created or re-created. It is what is and can never be grasped in its totality. As human beings, we merely can experience parts of it at varying levels (2000, p.3)”. Music mimics the implicate order due to the time-ordered structure of musical elements such as pitch, tempo, rhythm, melody, and harmony. The second source is meaning as *experienced*. This is when a person experiences part of the implicate order and finds meaning from their encounter with it. Experience is ineffable and is often not translatable into words. Music is a wonderful vessel for processing meaning from experience as it is often far easier to put experiences, thoughts, and feelings into musical context rather than words (Bruscia, 2000). It is important to note that experience is always unique and individualized due to the huge number of factors in how a person experiences shared reality. For example, their personality, their previous life experiences, and their openness to observation and introspection will all play a role in how a person experiences encounters with shared reality. The third source of meaning is meaning as *constructed*. Through reflection, thought, action, and creative engagement, a person continually constructs and re-constructs the meaning of their experiences with implicate order. By reflecting on the experience of shared reality and relating it to previous experiences, values, and beliefs, a person discovers new meanings, often for the same experience at different points in their life (Bruscia, 2000).

Though these two views on sources of meaning may appear at first to conflict, there is a great deal of overlap. Suffering, as in Frankl’s model, may align with experiencing shared reality in Bruscia’s theory. Encounters with reality, or implicate order, can often be painful and a cause of

suffering. Experiencing a value (logotherapy) aligns with Bruscia's idea of experiencing reality. Through experiencing reality, a person often discovers their values and beliefs. And logotherapy's view of doing an action as a source of meaning aligns with Bruscia's construction of meaning. By taking responsibility for one's actions and choices, a person constructs new meaning for themselves.

The principles of music therapy overlap with several other key concepts of logotherapy. Frankl's meaning triangle (1962) posits three ways to find meaning: creativity, experiences with things and people outside oneself, and choosing one's attitude. These pathways to meaning discovery overlap with the four methods of music therapy. The experiential corner of the triangle relates primarily to recreative and compositional methods, because they allow clients to interact with musical instruments, sounds, texture, structure, melody, timbre, etc. They also allow for the experience of relationship, whether the relationship is client to therapist, client to other clients, client to self or client to music. The creativity corner relates most strongly to improvisation, as this method supports the client in exploring new musical ideas and sounds without judgment. Improvisation encourages clients to find new ways to express themselves and thus to create completely novel music. Receptive methods link to the third corner, attitude. Whether and how a client chooses to interpret song lyrics, relax to a music imagery, or move to music is solely their decision. Clients are just as welcome to decline to engage as they are to engage in a music experience. Furthermore, the music often motivates clients to participate, even when they start out with an attitude of disengagement and avoidance.

Another concept connecting logotherapy and music therapy is the ontological view of humans. Frankl's conception of human existence is as body (soma), mind (psyche) and spirit (noetic core). Music therapy is a whole-person therapy. As the above definition from the World Federation of Music Therapy states, music therapy can address "...physical, social, communicative, emotional, intellectual, and spiritual health and wellbeing (World Federation of

Music Therapy, 2023).” While the goals of music therapy may target specific domains, music is a whole-brain, whole-body experience (Hodges, 2020). Therefore, all three dimensions of a client’s humanity is engaged in every music therapy experience.

The model by Pattakos and Dunden (2017), who framed Frankl’s original ideas into seven basic principles, will be utilized to explain how music therapy helps clients to find meaning in their lives. These principles include 1. exercise the freedom to choose your attitude; 2. realize your will to meaning; 3. detect the meaning of life’s moments; 4. don’t work against yourself; 5. look at yourself from a distance; 6. shift your focus of attention; and 7. extend beyond yourself.

This model was chosen for its simplicity, clarity, and integrity to Frankl’s original intent. As the authors point out, “whenever we suffer – no matter the severity of our suffering – we have the ability to find meaning in the situation. We also have the ability to find meaning in the good times. Choosing to find meaning, under any circumstance, is the path to a meaningful life (Pattakos & Dunden, 2017, p. 5)”. Music therapy is a challenging yet engaging modality through which clients can explore their multidimensionality and discover the meaning of their life experiences.

Applying Logotherapy Principles to Music Therapy

Principle 1. How music therapy helps clients exercise the freedom to choose their attitude

This principle posits that all people, regardless of their situation, have the freedom to choose their attitude. Sears (1996) was among the earliest music therapists to discuss how music might impact the ways in which individuals choose to respond. In his classification of music experiences offered to an individual client, “experiences in relating to others (Sears, 1996, p. 34)” best portrays Frankl’s principle of actively choosing one’s attitude. One of the most obvious ways music allows for this active choice is by providing opportunities to respond in unique ways. For example, imagine that a small group of adults hospitalized with depression are being guided through a non-structured musical improvisation by a music therapist. For this task, they are presented with a collection of handheld multicultural instruments. In this scenario, each client has

myriad choices of how they will engage. They can choose the instrument, the volume level, the various ways in which they wish to play, whether to match the beat or not, whether to interact with group members, and more. In a simple five-minute musical improvisation, a single client has any number of opportunities to exercise choice – including the frequently-observed choice to change their mind (Bruscia, 2013).

Every music therapy intervention offers clients autonomy in how they will respond to the music presented to them, and the clients' musical behaviors are supported to every extent possible (Polen, Shultis & Wheeler, 2017). Clients are also given the choice to feel whatever feelings and attitude they currently have. A well-trained music therapist will adjust the music to support the client's or group's emotional state as it changes from moment to moment (Bruscia, 2013).

A second more subtle experience involving choice that Sears (1996) describes is the chance to accept responsibility for self and others (p.34). An example of this is a group of adolescents with behavioral difficulties in a therapeutic rock band. These youngsters must work together with their music therapist to determine who will take responsibility for guitar, keyboard, drum set, bass, and lead vocals. They also must choose songs and a band name and work together to learn and practice their parts. The most important part of a therapeutic rock band is taking responsibility not only for one's own musical role but supporting the other group members in fulfilling their musical roles as well.

Responsibility for one's or others' roles happens frequently in music therapy (Bruscia, 2013). Any group music experience contains this element. A song or other music-based discussion involves both taking responsibility for one's own sharing and accepting that others have a role in contributing to the group discussion. Likewise, a group songwriting experience implies that everyone in the group will have some role, and therefore some responsibility, in both the process of songwriting and in the final product of the song. And any active music making such as the above

improvisation example necessitates responsibility on the part of all group members, the least of which is the responsibility to participate appropriately and safely with the instruments.

A third and perhaps the most socially relevant experience that Sears describes is that music therapy supports the learning of social skills and acceptable behavior patterns within one's community (1996, p.34). This can be seen in a group for pre-school children on the Autism spectrum where the music therapist is helping them work on respecting personal space, which they call "The Bubble". As they are guided through a fun song about respecting the bubble, the children respond to the therapist's sung cues by either jumping inside their "bubbles" (hula hoops laid on the floor) or outside their "bubbles". Their hoops are moved closer together or further away as the children learn to communicate their personal needs to each other. This song is then used outside the music therapy room as a reminder whenever the children need to recall this important social skill.

While this example is about children, adults also benefit from the social skill development that happens naturally in music therapy groups. Even a very basic skill such as learning to respect other people's preferences (the doctrine of "don't yuck someone else's yum") is a frequent skill addressed in group music therapy with adults. Someone may not like a peer's choice of a favorite song, but being in a group setting encourages them to respect it just as they wish their own favorite song to be respected. Clients in music therapy groups also must learn to conduct themselves appropriately (Silverman, 2021). Depending on the specific setting, this may include being respectful of others, avoiding crosstalk, being on time, respecting the musical equipment, avoiding hateful language, dressing appropriately, being sober while in attendance, and contributing to the group.

Principle 2. How music therapy helps clients realize their will to meaning

Pattokos and Dunden (2017) describe this principle as the commitment to personal values and goals that can only be actualized by the individual. Clients who participate in music therapy

generally do so because they have a strong interest in music (Schultis, Wheeler, & Polen, 2017). When a client is interested in music, the music itself is often a gateway that motivates them to understand themselves because they want to understand the music. Music is processed throughout all parts of the brain - every lobe, every organ within the brain responds to music. This fact underscores that music is an instinctive human behavior (Hodges, 2020). The enjoyment that the human brain gets from music is intrinsically rewarding. Clients who might otherwise be resistant to therapy are more likely to engage in music therapy due to this reinforcing element (Bruscia, 2013; Polen, Shultis & Wheeler, 2017). Because music is an instinctive human behavior, it mirrors and heightens many other aspects of human behavior, including social interactions, learning new skills, and engaging in personal reflection (Hodges, 2020).

An example of this is when a client participates in a lyric analysis of a song. When the client can relate their personal experience to that expressed in the music and lyrics, they are far more motivated to understand their own experience through the lens of the song. Likewise, when a client engages in clinical improvisation, the music helps to lower their defenses and encourages them to explore the meaning of the music they created.

Finding meaning through suffering is an integral part of Frankl's theory (Frankl, 1962). Frankl emphasizes that all humans experience suffering and that a key task for humans is to discover the meaning underlying their suffering. Likewise, many music therapists acknowledge that to be human is to suffer, and therefore a primary focus for music therapy is the meaning that clients make of their suffering. In his article outlining his approach to working with foster care youth, Zanders (2015) explicitly states that finding meaning is the third stage of clinical work with these clients.

We had touched on his past traumatic experiences in finding resources, but John had not really found freedom from those experiences. John would at times still have flashbacks or other internal reminders of his abuse. In the stage of finding meaning,

it was important for me to provide a layer of support so that John could be vulnerable while still having sufficient ego strength to function in the world. Thus, in this stage, we used music experiences as a narrative for John's life so that he could find meaning in his past, build relationships in his present, and experience a more enriching future. In doing so, John was able to develop a more integrated identity and find meaning through his grief and loss (p 10).

Two aspects the music therapy treatment assisted John in discovering the meaning in his suffering. The first was developing his sense of identity and the second was through processing his multiple experiences of grief and loss. Through lyric analysis, songwriting, and musical improvisation, John "came to a realization...that being loved, cared for, and feeling secure was important for him... He was able to....reconstruct the internal dynamics that were destroying his ability to establish healthy relationships (Zanders, 2015, p 8)."

This example demonstrates that the will to find meaning from suffering is pivotal for mental health. While Frankl recognizes that one does not have to suffer constantly to discover meaning, suffering is a natural part of life, and the will to understand what it means is a key factor in humans' ability to find peace and acceptance of their situation.

Principle 3. How music therapy helps clients detect the meaning of life's moments

The client is the only person who can find the meaning in each moment and take responsibility for their personal story. Music therapists often help clients work through challenging experiences such as grief, trauma, and serious illness. Zanders (2015) describes how a major component of his work using songwriting with a young man in the foster care system is about finding meaning from his worst experiences of abuse and trauma. The following excerpt demonstrates this:

Our songwriting was used to explore past relationships through the music. Themes that emerged, for example, were how John developed a lack of trust in adults,

distorted ideas about his sense of self, and feelings of shame, lack of self-worth, and avoidance of attachment. These songs were a representation of the meaning that John had found within the therapeutic process. This was the essence of our therapy: we worked together to find meaning in John's life, while I provided the necessary resources for him to do so. The songs became artifacts of the therapeutic process and relationship (p. 103).

By providing musical resources through actions such as songwriting, improvisation with chosen instruments, singing meaningful songs, or discussing music with biographical relevance, music therapists help their clients find meaning in even the most difficult life experiences. In an arts-informed research study by Rykov (2008), one client writes directly about how her experience participating in a music therapy cancer support group has given her a new sense of meaning regarding her cancer diagnosis, one that has allowed her to let go of the need for control:

You know that the pauses between, and the dynamics of, the music showed me that there was so much more of unspoken language with music that we don't talk about with words, that we can only talk about with music. And there is something so incredibly beautiful about that, just to be able to be free with sound in a group, with a group of people who've come there to create this space to communicate...Any illusion of control I thought I had in my life was destroyed when I received my cancer diagnosis. Here in music therapy the music is neither directed nor controlled, but created—like a life. This was very empowering (p. 196).

Principle 4. How music therapy helps clients learn not to work against themselves

This fourth principle states that clients should avoid becoming fixated on certain outcomes to the point that they end up working against the desired result. Engaging in music therapy, like other therapeutic modalities, helps clients learn creative problem-solving skills and identify ways in which they might be self-sabotaging in their lives (Rolsvjord, 2010). Because music helps to

relax defenses (as shown in the previous section), clients in music therapy are more likely to be open and vulnerable, which allows for greater clinical progress. Frankl warns of the existential vacuum, wherein life has no value because it has no meaning (Frankl, 1962). Clients in the existential vacuum tend to put up many defenses and barriers because therapy, and even life itself, seems pointless.

Musicking often stimulates unpredictable responses in clients. In clinical improvisation, for example, neither the client nor therapist knows where the music will go. All that is known at the start is that there is huge potential for creativity, aesthetic experience, and exploration of meaning (Bruscia, 2000). Many times, the improvisation leads to far deeper places than either party was expecting (Gardstrom, 2009). If the client is focused on a specific outcome, they may miss the opportunity to learn something truly meaningful about themselves. Music's fluid, temporal, and aesthetic nature helps keep clients in the moment and less focused on the "purpose" of the activity. Another way that music prevents self-sabotage is through the imagery it induces (Bonny, 2002). Through listening to specially chosen classical music in a non-ordinary state of consciousness (such as happens during a session of Guided Imagery and Music – Bonny Method), clients experience completely unpredictable imagery, emotions, and sensations that simply cannot be anticipated as a discrete outcome of the session. This ambiguity of where the music will take someone allows for huge potential to discover meaning.

Principle 5. How music therapy helps clients look at themselves from a distance

Humans have a unique quality of being able to view themselves with perspective and even humor. Music can help clients gain this perspective. Music therapists believe that music is a context-dependent and universal human need (Hodges, 2020; Bruscia, 2013). Musical behavior satisfies the human desire for meaningful experiences and connection. Clients can look at their strengths, weaknesses, desires, preferences, thoughts and actions through the lens of musical experiences and thereby gain some objectivity or detachment toward their inner life. One example

is using lyric analysis. Lyric analysis is the process by which clients listen closely to both music and lyrics and then discuss the song's relevance to their own experience as a mechanism to gaining personal or collective insight. Through engagement in a lyric analysis, the client can view the relevant clinical theme through the eyes of the artist who is singing about it. From there they can draw connections to their own thoughts and actions around this theme. An example of this is the song *Acid Tongue* by Jenny Lewis (2008). The first verse and chorus are as follows:

I went to a cobbler to fix a hole in my shoe
 He took one look at my face and said, "I can fix that hole in you"
 "I beg your pardon, I'm not looking for a cure
 I've seen enough from my friends in the depths of the God-sick blues"
 You know I am a liar (Liar)
 You know I am a liar (Liar)
 Nobody helps a liar (Liar) (Lewis, 2008, track 5).

The songwriter expresses deep emotions through intentional and likely intuitive use of musical elements such as melody, key, rhythm, form, and instrumentation. By closely reading and listening to this song, a client may gain a more objective view of their own struggle with addiction, including using drugs or alcohol to avoid difficult emotions and lying to people around them to maintain their addiction. A client may realize that they have been using chemicals to fix the wrong hole or problem. It is far safer emotionally for the client to focus on the songwriter first. This provides enough personal distance that they can start to see themselves more objectively (Bruscia, 2013; Crowe, 2017).

Philosophers of music therapy agree that music supports the client's ability to see themselves from a distance. According to Zanders (2025), music helps to create a metaphorical bridge that clients can choose to cross:

Music therapy, as an art form, excels not only in facilitating personal and collective narratives but also in enriching the lives of its participants by constructing deep, meaningful experiences through musical engagement. It acts as a dynamic bridge between the conscious and the subconscious, offering clients a profound canvas on which to explore their identities, confront their fears, and celebrate their victories.

Through the process of engaging with music, individuals articulate their stories, finding resonance with both personal and communal truths, thereby interlacing meaning as they navigate their therapeutic process (Zanders, 2025, p. 114).

This bridge created by music helps clients to gain perspective on their thoughts, feelings, and choices.

Principle 6. How music therapy helps clients shift their focus of attention

Frankl's principle of shifting attention aligns closely with the concept of coping skills. It is crucial for people to develop effective and safe strategies for dealing with difficult emotions so they can then engage in meaning exploration from a place of emotional and physical safety (Crowe, 2017). Music therapy helps clients to shift their attention in several ways. First, the music itself is a distraction from their day-to-day problems, fears, and worries. The brain is very responsive to music, especially preferred music (Bruscia, 2013; Schultis, Wheeler & Polen, 2017), so even for clients who might otherwise refuse to participate in therapy, music is a very stimulating distraction. This shift of focus often happens without conscious awareness. For example, due to various neurochemical responses in the thalamus and the cerebellum, the brain will align with a strong external rhythm (Hodges, 2020). Evidence of this can be seen in clients tapping their foot, patting their knees, or swaying with the rhythm before they are even aware of it. In this sense, music literally shifts attention.

Another way music can shift a client's attention is through the recognition of similar patterns (Hodges, 2020; Crowe, 2017). A client might notice a pattern or a story that is expressed

through a piece of music and recognize some similarity to a pattern or story in their own life. This recognition can help to shift a client's attention away from fears and towards an understanding of a new insight about themselves. One example of this is when a group does an egg shaker pass. In this intervention, clients stand or sit in a circle and pass egg shakers in a specific pattern – picking it up with their right hand and setting it down in the left hand of the person to their left. Clients must work together and listen to be successful at this rhythm game. When the group is asked to reverse the direction, there is often reluctance or fear that they will mess it up. However, the shift in direction often goes better than clients expect. When the group is asked to notice how changing directions in life is also scary, they start to see the analogy: changing directions is hard, but it can be done, and it usually is not as frightening or impossible as they anticipated. By experiencing this concept in the safety and fun of a music therapy group, the clients come away with a meaningful shift in focus that can apply to their lives outside the therapy session.

Finally, a positive experience with music can help shift a client away from negative thoughts and behaviors (Hodges, 2020; Silverman, 2021). When used strategically, music can help clients shift from all types of negative emotional and cognitive states to more positive or neutral ones. Music for relaxation can shift a client from an anxious, tense or fearful state to calm and grounded. Lyric analysis can shift a depressed client from negative self-talk to more neutral affirmations, helping them to improve their mood. Musical improvisation or songwriting can help someone struggling with addiction to manage triggers and shift to a positive coping strategy instead of relying on substances to deal with difficult emotions. Finally, at the most basic level, engagement in musical activities such as playing the drums can help a child with behavioral problems manage anger and impulse control.

Principle 7. How music therapy helps clients extend beyond themselves

This principle focuses on the human need to believe in something bigger than oneself. The power of music is greatest in a group (Gaston, 1968). This simple idea is a key principle in the

discipline of music therapy. When people engage in musical behavior with at least one other person, the result is a synergistic musical product that cannot be created by a single person. This principle helps music therapy clients to extend beyond themselves and appreciate the bigger picture so that they can be part of a unique musical experience. This extension happens by focusing on the role that one plays and by listening to the sound of the whole as opposed to just one's own sound (Gaston, 1968; Sears, 1996). In group improvisation, clients must listen to each other to create a pleasing sound; otherwise, the various instruments and rhythms become chaotic. Likewise, when recreating a song for therapeutic purposes (such as in a rock band music therapy group), each client must focus on their role in the group and be reliable and accountable to the rest of the group. Whether they are playing keyboard, drums, guitar, or singing, each client needs to regulate themselves so that they can be reliable for the group. When writing a song, a client must extend beyond what they think they can do to create a piece of music they can be proud of. In this way, music therapy helps clients to tap into resources they did not know, or perhaps forgot, that they had. Music therapy encourages clients to identify and utilize all their resources, including those outside themselves. Clients often discover new things about themselves through music therapy, such as a greater ability to problem-solve, to make different decisions in their lives, or to use music as a resource.

Music is a great vehicle for empathy. Through it, clients can recognize other people's suffering and joy and start to see how they fit into their community. This empathy promotes the connection to something greater than the individual. Additionally, music is well-known for its role in spirituality and religious practice (Hodges, 2020). Through engagement in music, whether listening, singing, composing, or improvising, clients can more easily tap into their spirituality, literally helping them to connect to a higher plane of existence (Crowe, 2017).

Conclusion

Using the analogy of an ophthalmologist, Frankl (1962) describes the role of the logotherapist as broadening the client's visual field, allowing for all potential meaning to become visible. By applying the seven logotherapy principles listed above to the discipline of music therapy, it is clear how engaging in musical behavior can broaden the "visual field" of clients so that they can perceive the range of possible meanings in their lives, and the meanings their lives have for the world. Through the alignment of the three sources of meaning between logotherapy and music therapy theorists, these seven principles provide a wholistic lens through which music therapists from a variety of clinical approaches can view meaning in music therapy.

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Editorial Review Article

A Personal Narrative of How Bruce Springsteen's Logo-Philosophy Music Helped Me Discover Meaning as an Adolescent and Young Man: Meditations on Death, Suffering, Hope, Relationships and Self-Transcendence

Rodney B. Dieser

Frankl was a sober realist . . . His philosophy was not about wishing away problems or pretending they do not exist, but rather to acknowledge them in their grim reality. Yet in spite of this realism, or rather because of it, he describes how holding onto hope was literally a life-or-death choice. Those who lost hope, he said, developed a certain look in their eye, a fatalism that inevitably ended in death. They experienced an “existential vacuum” — his term for a complete loss of meaning, a loss of hope, a sense that nothing really mattered anymore.

The above quotation by Muldoon (2020), a professor in the Department of Philosophy at Boston College, was part of his discussion on how to face hardships with hope during the early part of the COVID-19 lockdowns. I recently read Muldoon's article, and as I read it today (not during the COVID lockdowns), I think it applies just as well to Bruce Springsteen, an iconic American rock musician, singer-songwriter, and humanitarian. This paper outlines how Bruce Springsteen's music acknowledges the grim reality and suffering of everyday Americans, and how many of his songs describe holding onto hope as a literal life-or-death choice. That is, many Springsteen songs are built on a foundation of logo-philosophy, songs that underscore finding meaning in suffering. Whereas many Springsteen songs end bleak, outlining the consequences of a loss of meaning and hope (existential vacuum) many of his other songs accentuate discovering meaning in suffering. This paper ends with a personal narrative of how the Springsteen song, Wreck on the Highway, helped me discover meaning in relationships, and self-transcendence, as my mother was dying of terminal cancer and died one week after I graduated from high school.

Bruce Springsteen and His Music

Bruce Springsteen was born in New Jersey in 1949, and his music often reflects his blue collar working-class roots and the Jersey Shore scene. Springsteen became a national sensation in the mid-1970s, with *Newsweek* and *Time* magazines featuring him on their covers simultaneously, highlighting his unique and authentic storytelling and iconic rock and roll sound. Springsteen has written and recorded nearly 400 officially released tracks and over 1,400 total songs in his database.¹ Springsteen has received 20 Grammy Awards, an Academy Award, two Golden Globes, and a special Tony Award. He has also been honored with top civilian awards, including the Presidential Medal of Freedom.

Per lyrical themes, Springsteen songs are short stories that explore the struggles, sufferings, dreams, and spirit of everyday Americans, often with a focus on hope, purpose, and resilience, as well as how to build a better America (Dolan, 2012). Coles (2003) views Springsteen's songs about real-life Americans and American society as an activity in existential philosophy. To this end, Coles draws on ten research interviews to posit that Springsteen's songwriting is akin to American literary figures like Walt Whitman and John Steinbeck, viewing his songs (short stories) as helping people engage in spiritual and existential reflection connected to the larger and more important matters of life. Two examples of these firsthand accounts is a teacher who used the stark narratives of the *Nebraska* (album) to connect with students on existential themes in their personal lives and a police officer who reflects on his community role (purpose) in response to American Skin (41 Shots) (song). In addition, Coles also posited that Springsteen's songs provide documentary glimpses of America, such as how the early 1980s recession in America affected everyday Americas in *The River* album.

¹ Although Springsteen started producing albums in 1973, and his most recent album, *Only the Strong Survive*, was produced in 2022, the music articulated in this manuscript that influenced my development as an adolescent and young man are from his albums from 1975 to 1993.

Perhaps Springsteen's most famous song is *Born in the USA*, released in 1984, from the *Born in the USA* album. Despite the song's anthemic, sing-along chorus, *Born in the USA* (song) tells the story of a disillusioned Vietnam War veteran returning home to a country where he feels forgotten and faces economic hardship and a lack of support (Shook, 2008). *Born in the USA* was partially inspired by Ron Kovic's (1976) memoir, *Born on the Fourth of July*, which chronicled Kovic's journey from a young man who volunteers for the Vietnam War to a paralyzed anti-war activist (Springsteen, 2016). In short, *Born in the USA* (song) shares the suffering of many US Vietnam Veterans, with the main character's life outlined as such:

- A man born in a dysfunctional family and being physically abused at a young age (“Born down in a dead man's town / The first kick I took was when I hit the ground / You end up like a dog that's been beat too much / 'Til you spend half your life just coverin' up”)
- The narrator gets involved with crime (“a hometown jam”) and can choose going to Vietnam to kill the “yellow man” or serving time in prison. The narrator chose service in Vietnam.²
- When the narrator returns home, suffering with post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), life becomes worse, and he becomes jobless and homeless. The refinery will not re-hire him and will not tell him why (most likely due to PTSD), and the VA (Department of Veterans Affairs) provides no support or help.
- The only love this narrator experienced in his life is the love between his deceased brother and a woman in Saigon, whom he locates in a picture. His brother died in the battle at Khe Sanh.³

² During the Vietnam War era, some judges offered young men convicted of minor crimes a choice between jail time or joining the military, a common but informal practice leveraging the draft, though not an official federal policy. The military later prohibiting it due to higher standards and changing times.

³ The Battle of Khe Sanh was one of the longest and bloodiest engagements of the Vietnam War, a 77-day siege pitting U.S. Marines and their South Vietnamese allies against the North Vietnamese Army (NVA) from January to July 1968.

- The song ends with no future; the narrator is trapped between the cold penitentiary and burning refinery of his past (prison and past blue collar employment that will not hire him).

Born in the USA was produced in 1984, approximately ten years after the end of the Vietnam War,⁴ and the ending lyrics of the song are exact: “I’m ten years burning down the road / Nowhere to run ain’t got nowhere to go.” Bruce Springsteen is a sober realist, sharing grim stories of how some Vietnam Veterans were homeless ten years after the end of the war,⁵ existing in an existential vacuum.

Drawing on Margotin and Guesdon (2020), below is a sampling of songs I listened to as an adolescent and young adult that outlined suffering as a human condition:

- *Dancing in the Dark*: Articulates the feeling of being stuck and yearning for escape from the mundane and depression.
- *The River*: A heartbreaking story of young love derailed by unwanted pregnancy and the crushing reality of daily life.
- *Adam Raised a Cain*: An intense representation of an abusive father-son relationship.
- *Independence Day*: Underscores the struggle with a father's mental health and a son's failing attempts to connect.
- *Streets of Philadelphia*: A portrayal of isolation, illness, and invisibility in the city.
- *Factory*: An austere look at the repetitive, soul-crushing nature of blue collar working-class life.
- *Tunnel of Love*: The song (and entire album) explore marital breakdown and disillusionment in life.

⁴ The last American combat troops departed from Vietnam, completing the U.S. withdrawal in 1973. In April of 1975, the North Vietnamese forces captured Saigon, leading to the reunification of Vietnam under communist rule.

⁵ Seven years after Springsteen produced *Born in the USA* a 43 site Veterans Affairs assessment/study suggested that of 10,524 homeless veterans 50 percent served during the Vietnam War era, compared to only 29 percent of all veterans in the general population (Rosenheck, Gallup & Leda, 1991). Sixteen years later, the National Coalition for Homeless Veterans (2007) outlined that 47% of homeless veterans served during the Vietnam Era.

Most Springsteen albums are concept albums that explore a certain topic. For example, the 1982 *Nebraska* album explores dark, tragic tales of alienated, down-on-their-luck working-class Americans, presenting lonely characters who face despair, crime, and broken dreams. Nebraska, the song (on the *Nebraska* album) was inspired by the real-life crime of Charles Starkweather,⁶ along with the writings of Flannery O'Connor, known for writing Southern Gothic literature (Zanes, 2023). Most Springsteen albums feature songs of hope that have characters who discover meaning in suffering, often as the final track on the album. For example, the last song on *Nebraska* is Reason to Believe, a hopeful song that, in a profoundly complex and understated way, highlights humanity's resilience by finding small reasons to believe (meaning) despite intense suffering. Springsteen's 2020 *The Rising* album is an articulation of the September 11th attacks in the United States, exploring themes of grief, loss, hope, healing, and resilience through the eyes of victims, families, and first responders. This album is a reflection on finding strength in faith and rebuilding after trauma, featuring stories of firefighters, lost loved ones, and a search for meaning amidst devastation, all unified by a longing for human connection and transcendence. Its last song, My City of Ruins, ends with a call to "rise up" and find hope and meaning in community, and another song, Into the Fire, is based on an interview with Stacey Farrelly whose husband died as a firefighter on 9/11, is about discovery meaning and finding strength in the death of her heroic husband (Margotin & Guesdon, 2020).

Drawing on Margotin and Guesdon (2020), below is a sampling of songs I listened to as an adolescent or young adult that outlined hope, determination, grit, and discovering meaning in suffering

- Thunder Road: A call to escape origins and chase a relationship (meaning) with someone.
- The Promised Land: A person searching for a better life; believing in a better future and fighting for those dreams.

⁶ Charles Starkweather was an American spree killer who murdered eleven people in Nebraska and Wyoming between December 1957 and January 1958.

- *Badlands*: A powerful declaration to overcome adversity and chase dreams and meaning despite harsh realities.
- *Born to Run*: While about escaping a stifling town, it embodies hope and discovering meaning through the power of love and shared escape.
- *Dancing in the Dark*: A plea for connection, finding hope and meaning in shared experience to overcome boredom, stagnation, and depression.
- *Living Proof*: Speaks to finding purpose in the struggle for truth.

In October of 2025, the biopic *Springsteen: Deliver Me from Nowhere* was released in movie theaters in the United States, and chronicles Springsteen's personal struggles and the creation of *Nebraska* album (and its deep connection to the *Born in the USA* album, produced two years later).⁷ Drawing deeply from Springsteen's (2016) biography and Zanes' (2023) historical research, this movie underscores Bruce Springsteen's understanding of his father's (Douglas Springsteen) errors and abusive ways, and from these insights, finding forgiveness and working toward developing a relationship.⁸ Forgiveness, as an attitudinal choice in the face of unfairness and pain, aligns with Frankl's attitudinal values and his theory of self-transcendence, which involves looking beyond oneself to a larger perspective or purpose (Frankl, 1969/1988). Although beyond the scope of this paper, Springsteen's songs also teach social perspective-taking skills, the ability to understand other people, including their struggles, and why and how they make their decisions (Dieser, 2014).

⁷ *Nebraska* and *Born in the U.S.A.* developed from the same writing sessions. *Nebraska's* stark, solo demos were recorded first, but Springsteen kept many of the songs (e.g., *Born in the U.S.A.* song) and later electrified them with the E Street Band, creating two contrasting yet twinned albums reflecting struggling Americans, with *Nebraska's* characters developing into the *Born in the U.S.A.* characters. See Zanes (2023).

⁸ Carlin (2012) outlines Douglas Springsteen trauma-filled childhood. His older sister (aged five) died by getting hit by a truck playing on her tricycle. This resulted in Douglas's mother spending two years in bed due to grief, then neglected Douglas and sending him to live with other relatives. Douglas Springsteen was diagnosed with bipolar disorder/schizophrenia late in his life, often self-medicated with alcohol (Springsteen, 2016).

My Family Background and Why Springsteen Stories Resonated

I grew up in an immigrant family in southern Alberta, Canada. My mother, the firstborn in Canada from a family that immigrated from Hungary, could not read nor drive a car. She was first diagnosed with cancer when I was 11 years of age and died one week after I graduated from high school. My father, who immigrated to Canada from Germany at the age of 15, could read at a sixth-grade level and worked in construction. My father was authoritarian and emotionally detached, but not abusive. Family members, including my older brother and sister, did not discuss serious or emotional issues, and there was no bi-directional communication or social perspective-taking. Although I never doubted that my parents loved me and loved each other, my parents dealt with my mother's incurable cancer in an unhealthy and disconnected way by not talking about it, and my parents asked me to promise not to tell anyone. It was a dark secret that I kept to myself. I remember identifying with the Springsteen song "Darkness on the Edge of Town," with its lyrics "Everybody's got a secret Sonny / Something that they just can't face." Due to my parents' trauma-oriented childhoods (e.g., my father experienced hunger, extreme poverty/homelessness as a child victim of World War II in Europe, and my mother experienced physical abuse and poverty), they did not have childhood experiences or environments that would foster healthy development. Since my mother battled cancer for seven years, and my family struggled financially,⁹ my parents did not have the physical or emotional energy, the educational background, or the financial resources that were helpful in fostering development.

Today, I understand why I connected to the themes of death, fear, and loneliness in Springsteen's 1980 *The River* album when I was an adolescent, as it reflected my life. This was the first Springsteen album I purchased, and I listened to it repeatedly. As Kirkpatrick (2007) posits, "fear pervades the [*River*] album. If *The River* is Springsteen's most playful, it's also his most depressing album . . . Songs throughout the album ponder the sense of loss when dreams are lost."

⁹ My parents never enrolled any of their children in any type of youth or community program, whether educational, recreational, musical, writing, sports, or nature based. They simply did not have any extra money.

(p. 74-75). For me, knowing (in junior high) that my mother had cancer and eventually knowing that her breast cancer became a terminal bone cancer (in high school) was the dichotomy of dreams and reality, and caused me to ponder when dreams are lost. The song Stolen Car provides the chilly feeling of emotional isolation (Carlin, 2012) as Springsteen sings with just a gentle acoustic guitar and piano, as a car thief has sunk into self-destructive sadness and loneliness after the dream of his marriage ends, with the concluding verse outlining fear: “And I’m driving a stolen car / On a pitch black night / And I’m telling myself I’m gonna be alright / But I ride by night and I travel in fear / That in this darkness I will disappear.” Although I was not involved in stealing cars or any criminal behavior, I connected with the depressive notions and fear shared in Stolen Car.

Wreck on the Highway and its Logo-Philosophy of Finding Hope in Suffering and Death

The song from *The River* album that helped me the most then and remains at the foundation of my life today is Wreck on the Highway. The main character has witnessed a car accident on a county two-lane highway and realizes that later in the night, a state trooper is going to knock on the door of a house to tell a girlfriend or a young wife that her lover has died in a wreck on the highway. The lyrics at the end of the song are deeply existential and logo-philosophical, as this character, through the social perspective-taking of a death event, has now realized what the most essential part of his life is – his female partner. Similar to Frankl’s death bed technique where he has clients imagine they are on their deathbed reviewing their life to discover meaning, “. . . a meaning which even included all of her sufferings” (p. 140), death awareness from Wreck on the Highway caused, for me, acute mindfulness of the shortness of life and how we need to hold precious the most important people in our lives:

Sometimes, I sit up in the darkness

And I watch my baby as she sleeps

Then I climb in bed and I hold her tight.

I just lay there awake in the middle of the night

Thinking 'bout the wreck on the highway

Frankl (1946/2019) posited that because there is a certainty of death, this awareness can help people create a sense of urgency and responsibility to make the most of our limited time and to focus our attention on those things that are highest in meaning.

If we were immortal, we could legitimately postpone every action forever. It would be of no consequence whether or not we did a thing now; every act might just as well be done tomorrow or the day after or a year from now or ten years hence. But in the face of death as absolute finis to our future and boundary to our possibilities, we are under the imperative of utilizing our lifetimes to the utmost, not letting the singular opportunities... pass by unused (p. 64).

Awareness of one's own death or others can be a catalyst for meaning. As a young man, Wreck on the Highway helped me realize that relationships of love are most important in life and motivated me to want to develop a deep, loving relationship with a woman and have children. I have been able to live this logos – just celebrating my 35th wedding anniversary and having three wonderful adult sons. Wreck on the Highway, just like Frankl's (1946/1984) *Man's Search For Meaning*, reminds me that life can end suddenly at any time, so I need to live my logos each day and cherish those I love, engaging in both meaning in the moment and ultimate meaning. As Frankl (1946/2019) summed “. . . the greatness of life can be measured by the greatness of a moment . . . and a single moment can retroactively flood an entire life with meaning" (p. 44). Today I know, as Frankl (1946/1984) underscored, that meaning can be discovered in loving relationships, helping us transcend ourselves and connect to something greater than ourselves. My mother's death, and its anticipatory fear and consequential pain, caused me to discover meaning in relationships, but Springsteen songs help bring clarity to this logo-philosophy ideology, as I used his logo-philosophy music to process my feelings well before I knew of Viktor Frankl and the concept of finding meaning in suffering. Wreck on the Highway, and the many other Springsteen songs that

brought awareness of death (e.g., *My Father's House*) helped me reframe fear of death to cherishing and striving toward loving relationships, linked to self-transcendence.

Conclusion

Both Viktor Frankl and Bruce Springsteen were sober realists. Both acknowledge the grim reality of life and give voice that the human condition is full of suffering. Yet, in spite of this realism, or rather because of it, both describe how holding onto hope can be a life-or-death choice, and both shared real-life stories; those who discover meaning and self-transcendence through suffering and those who lost hope and spiraled into an existence void of meaning. To my knowledge, Bruce Springsteen has not acknowledged Viktor Frankl in a recorded interview or public statement; however, the aim of this article is to outline how Bruce Springsteen's music is built on a foundation of logoi philosophy, with songs that accentuate the discovery of meaning in suffering. To this end, the last part of this manuscript presents a personal narrative of me sharing how the Springsteen song, *Wreck on the Highway*, helped me discover meaning in relationships and self-transcendence, as my mother was dying of cancer. Although I first listened to *Wreck on the Highway* approximately forty years ago, today this song reminds me that life can end suddenly at any time, so I need to live my logoi each day and cherish those I love, engaging in both meaning in the moment and ultimate meaning.

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Logotherapy as a Means of Passing Meaning Forward: A Logotherapeutic Framework for Teachers Supporting Next-Generation Music Pedagogues Amid Systemic and Cultural Pressures

Tanja M. Torvikoski

Self-distancing or self-detachment and self-transcendence, the two agents of the Noological dimension, reveal the existence of the Noological dimension to a person. They will (a) evaluate their own condition or situation and the limitations, opportunities and purposes it brings from the perspective of free will, or (b) evaluate the purposeful consequences of their own actions for others, towards whom they reach out (value-oriented way of thinking and acting) (Niiles-Mäki, 2024). These are the abilities that constitute a person and characterize a person as a person (Frankl, 2014). Their actions can therefore be considered primary in relation to the other properties of the Noological dimension (the will to purpose, conscience, faith and the Defiant Power of Spirit), which are called the qualities of the Noological dimension. (Niiles-Mäki, 2024). The qualities are born or developed in the interaction between agents and situational or transcendental reality. Music provides a conducive environment to practice the Noological agents intentionally, on the condition that the Noological dimension has been activated and that the person is using their free will to actively operate them. The healing, meaning and happiness, that is a direct result of submitting oneself under the guidance of conscience and universal values can be invoked in music-making alone or with others, when the Noological dimension is active. Musical practice and music-making invite us to learn to flow through situations with a meaningful and authentic presence – for some, it becomes an embodied way of life.

Music could therefore be considered as a logotherapeutic tool in itself; but without an activated Noological dimension and Noological tension to set meaningful intentions with proper guidance, the path of a musician or music pedagogue will go down a more self-concerned path,

that will eventually be challenged by our conscience, calling us out for not living in our true purpose. Music as a form of expression and music industry as a field of high comparison and competition will bring anyone intertwined with it to a point of self-reflection by design. Who am I in this situation? Why am I in this situation? How am I in this situation?

The activation of the Noological dimension of the human mind cannot be forced or rushed. Musical training and professional progression in music with its set standards can however lend a hand in a process resembling Noogenic Activation (NA) through setting us up against the hard questions of life that require self-distancing to be answered and by assuring us of the uniqueness of ourselves and our situation. Willingness to search and possibly discover potential for meaning in the moments, conscience, love, commitment to tasks, compassion, acceptance, forgiveness, courage, patience, gratitude, and many more are the resources of the human spirit, that a clinician could assist and guide the patient or student with who suffers from a acute or prolonged distortion with experiencing a purpose.

As a professor in voice and voice pedagogy and a musician and a team leader in higher-level music pedagogy education, I recognize the growing need among leadership as well as music educators for a structured and integrated understanding of values and purpose, as in Viktor Frankl's Logotherapy, for the next-generation of music pedagogues to be equipped to lead their profession and their future careers in a responsible, meaningful and personally fulfilling way as well as participating in the laying of a new foundation, where the growth and development of a Noologically aware future society can be built on.

Music and Self-Transcendence

Finnish music education has long been an internationally acknowledged success story. However, in recent decades, budget cuts and structural changes in social and educational policy have brought challenges to music education. At the same time, education is expected to provide

increasingly diverse options for music education and access to the proven wellbeing impact of music and music education (The Vision 2030 for Finnish Music Education).

Finnish educators in the field of music have been for some time now in an advocating position for the next generations to have, not just decent, but blossoming futures. This requires constant curricular readjustment and skills in motivating students to remain engaged with their studies, even though the profession they are training for is undergoing change and that the professional field is only so much understood in society. Pulled by self-transcendence beyond their situation, these music educators are living in purpose.

Today's music students observe the effort invested by their teachers, but they do not necessarily yet share the same value framework. For example, they have not yet internalized or adopted the underlying values that motivate that effort — such as long-term dedication, professional responsibility or a strong work ethic tied to the discipline of self-transcendence. What they have is their instrument in their hand and a dream of doing something worthwhile with it one day in a world that is spinning wildly, transforming beyond recognition before everyone's eyes. Our students face unseen storms at their age and need to be anchored in something more than secondhand values.

Sometimes professional self-confidence is born out of suffering, related to the artistic process or not, offering the artist the opportunity of turning their tragedies into triumphs with the help of Tragic Optimism and the Defiant Power of Spirit, that is always used in relation to the purpose-related values: Creative values, Experiential values and Attitudinal values easily accessible in music and music education. The suffering is always in the unresolved distortion of experiencing a purpose. In the genesis of a distortion related to experiencing a purpose, the functional process means the conflict between one of the two agents of Noological dimension — either self-distancing or self-transcendence — and the situation.

For a student to be supported accordingly in a time of existential struggle, teachers would benefit greatly of the knowledge of the Noological dimension of the human consciousness. The suffering person (e.g. a music student) if able to existentially transcend themselves over the tragic Triad, might proceed to help others through their gained experience, bringing new depth, credibility, relatability, and practical relevance to their future pedagogy as well as artistry. By introducing logotherapy to the field of music education and teachers – a reserve of highly caring people holding Noological resources in their back pockets – we could learn to recognize and articulate but also to use the Noological dimension, that is the medicine chest of the Logotherapist, more purposefully, to broaden our pedagogy to a new level of wholeness. There's no shortage of entry points in music, that allows us to peer through the Noological dimension and discover a new way of perception. Self-transcendence is important because it encompasses all other areas where meaning is available (self-discovery, choice, uniqueness, and responsibility), and because it provides purpose in exactly the area where you feel defeated: It turns your defeat into victory (Fabry, 2021).

Self-transcendence can be intentionally practiced in encounters with others and other beings (Niiles-Mäki, 2024). In musical dialogue, music speaks for itself, and the musician's role is not to impose meaning, but rather to listen and answer as truthfully as possible. This act of listening and following one's conscience, which shows a person the direction towards purposes situationally, is not self-effacing; rather, through service-oriented mentality, the person becomes more fully themselves—their identity, voice, and authenticity are realized through the self-transcending process.

Next-Generation of Music Pedagogues Amid Systemic and Cultural Pressures

According to the Finnish Youth Barometer 2024 by State Youth Council youth is experiencing a declining sense of hope in the future (2025). The perception that higher education no longer guarantees employment has proven true, as traditional jobs and career paths rapidly

transform and current higher-level education is not aligned with labor market needs. Weak overall economic conditions slow the job market down more. The aftermath of the global pandemic COVID-19 is showing in long-lasting effects, as youth faced disruption in their studies through long school closures and sudden shift to remote learning; loneliness caused by social isolation, an increased risk of anxiety and depression, and a heightened sensitivity to stress due to an uncertain future places the current youth and the previous generation in unequal positions, when it comes to starting points in life.

Meanwhile, competition to recruit graduate students within higher education institutions has intensified, as the prevailing financial model forces institutions to compete with one another for funding. On-time completion has become more important than the quality of the competencies acquired by students, as performance indicators emphasize the number of graduates rather than educational quality. “The purpose of the financing models”, explained by the Ministry of Education and Culture Finland (2025), “is to improve the quality, impact and productivity of the higher education institutions.”

In music education, this development has resulted in increasingly constrained timeframes for student graduation, alongside the growing demands imposed by a changing labor market. These measures are often justified as necessary to secure the continuity of music education for future generations. At the same time, they place significant pressure on a cohort of students whose educational trajectories have been shaped by unprecedented global disruptions and by expanded admissions policies introduced to sustain institutional viability. There is no time reserved for quiet contemplation and self-reflection in the system, systematically.

The systemic and cultural pressure is building up Spiritual/Noological distress, whose special manifestations are existential frustration and Existential Vacuum. In existential frustration, implementing a purpose is hindered, and this causes the experience of frustration (Niiles-Mäki, 2024). This is happening with a whole generation, and for that reason there is an increasing

demand for professionals with training in logotherapy to respond to what may be described as a wave of existential frustration signaling Noological awakening.

A Logotherapeutic Framework for Teachers Supporting Next-Generation

The core role of music educators is to carry societal responsibility for ensuring that musical skills are transmitted to future generations. Music education promotes equality, wellbeing, and inclusion. It supports life and learning skills, brings together people from diverse backgrounds, and contributes to the building of a sustainable future (The Vision 2030 for Finnish Music Education). Musical training and the musical collaboration with fellow musicians or with one's teacher allow numerous opportunities for intentional Noological stimulation and exploration in their holistic nature. Higher music education would benefit greatly from engagement with Viktor Frankl's work and could serve as an optimal platform for Logophilosophical experimentation within a pedagogical context. The need for organized guidance in existential questions among the academic youth is evident. Teachers are in key position in passing purposefulness forward as they work closely with their students, before a shared vocation.

To support the next generation of music pedagogues in establishing roots as they are called to education in the arts and culture, it is important that we as teachers can meet value-testing situations with dignity ourselves, and, through our commitment to values, with consistency—setting an example. The educators, the leaders and the decision-makers in higher music education are placed before unique opportunities and called not only meaningful but also purposeful action.

Now is the time to increase value- and purpose-oriented dialogue; to enhance knowledge and awareness regarding themes of values and purpose; to clarify the conceptual language connected to values and purpose; and, through this, to strengthen the ability to identify and interpret value orientations, supporting conscious, responsible, and stable life choices and actions. Logo-philosophy is understanding people from the perspective of Noological dimension and helping them from this perspective. It strives to understand and explain the diversity of human

existence in general and at the same time it provides new tools for everyone to understand their own way of existence.

Logo-philosophy is already used within educational and teaching settings, healthcare and social services, and various approaches to workplace development and wellbeing at work, however, logotherapeutic authority is needed in the broader discussion to introduce appreciable understanding of the holistic perception of the human, making way for the logo theory of human consciousness and the Noological dimension as part of it to be received and considered with its own qualities and agents.

With logotherapy, we could help address existential anxiety that so many are experiencing right now, hopefully initiating a lasting structural shift in higher education by creating space for value- and purpose-oriented content and consideration, and the integration of value- and purpose-driven pedagogical approaches – eventually across academic disciplines. This is to support the growth and development of a mentally aware and well-equipped generation and society. Viktor Frankl's logotherapy, which emphasizes dialogue and a value- and purpose-centered approach, would work as a ready framework for teachers supporting next-generation pedagogues amid systemic and cultural pressures toward a purposeful life and life skills grounded in the responsible understanding and use of free will.

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A Story of Music, Meaning, and One Simmering Moment...in a Church Basement*Marian Edmonds-Allen*

We met each week in the basement of a Unitarian Universalist Church in rural Utah. I was new, brought on to direct the youth program for LGBT teens – who turned out to not only be younger than I had expected, but many also didn't have homes to go to. They were homeless and slept in camps and abandoned railroad cars and empty buildings. I was new to Utah, new to this world of castaway children, and was newly ordained as a pastor. I was completely out of my element, and somehow, in charge, too. It must be a joke. The youth program was called OUTreach, and it was the only one like it: sponsored by progressive Christians and Jews, serving young teens from overwhelmingly conservative religious families. In a sense, one tribe taking in the castoff children of another tribe.

What helped everyone to get along was the food – and the music, always the music playing in the kitchen, and sometimes in the church gymnasium that also served as a dining hall. With people so different from each other, it was the music that brought us together, in ways that seem sacred to me now, maybe even holy. We affectionately called them the “church ladies”, the volunteers who showed up with overflowing bags of healthy food and snacks that they had scrounged to find on sale to meet our meager budget. But what could they do with the boxes of pasta, the bags of soup mix, the frozen tater tots and shredded cheese!

I knew what time it was not by glancing at my watch, but by the dozens of youth who would start to gather as the aromas drifted from the kitchen. And the church ladies would sing as they worked, moving from country twang to hymns, at times, and on spicy days, some show tunes, too. I watched the teens become gentle, remembering themselves, perhaps, as beloved children in their family kitchen. But they were beloved here, too, if strangers – yet strangers who gave us all purpose to come together, once a week, like a ritual.

One day we had a special speaker after dinner, a young, charismatic health department outreach worker, who was able to mesmerize the teens into learning about dating safety. They piled into a classroom together, laughing, and full of cheesy tater-tots, with some gooey brownies as an inducement to listen and learn. I stayed behind to clean the kitchen and bus the tables. The church ladies were long gone, off to do good somewhere else, no doubt. It was me, lots of used paper napkins and spilled red punch to scrub off the beat-up folding tables. I worked in silence, until I heard a song start to play:

“Every day is so wonderful...

Then suddenly it's hard to breathe”

I turned around to see one of the teens that I had come to know well. Harry was a quiet, slight, young blonde boy with eyes that sometimes would twinkle. He mostly kept to himself, but today he had someone with him that I had never seen before. She was transgender, and it was easy to tell. Many transgender people can “pass” – they can look like the gender they identify with, rather than the gender on their birth certificate. In order to pass you need money – money for clothing that fits your body and your sense of style, money for hair care, for electrolysis, for makeup – or you won’t “pass” at all, because visibility can be interpreted as provocation. Instead you become a target. A target of bullying, assault, and worse. The Transgender Day of Remembrance is a time to count the deaths that happen at the hands of assailants enraged by those who don’t “pass” well enough. It can be a death sentence. And here was the first transgender young person I had seen at the center whose visibility might make her a target — not because she lacked anything, but because society wasn’t ready to see her.

Willow was Latino, wearing clothes that she had likely had for some time, clothes made for a teen boy, but she also had a bit of lipstick, had styled her hair, and she had a small flower tucked behind one ear. She was swaying to the music that had grown a little bit louder as she stooped to help me gather the stray silverware that would inevitably end up in the trash barrels, discarded along with the paper plates. But we needed the silverware, and she knew that. Harry did, too.

We had moved on from the silverware to washing tables. Harry and his friend Willow paused, joined their hands and danced for just a moment, and in that moment, time seemed to stand still. The music, the movement, the moment...it didn't solve the unsolvable, what remained unspoken. But as the music swelled, that pause contained the feeling of being completely, utterly alive. The room shimmered.

“Now and then I get insecure

From all the pain

I'm so ashamed...”

... I am beautiful no matter what they say

Words can't bring me down

I am beautiful in every single way

Yes, words can't bring me down, oh no

So don't you bring me down today...”

Willow moved away then, off by herself to sort the salt and pepper shakers. Harry and I washed dishes in the kitchen.

The last time I saw Willow was just as we were turning off the lights. It was time to go home. Most of the teens had learned everything they needed to know about dating safety and received refrigerator magnets with tips to keep their new knowledge fresh. I wondered where

they'd put a magnet, these kids without kitchens. Maybe they would give them to the church ladies — who were long past needing dating advice, but never past giving it. Good would come of it.

But Willow, she was still there. Harry watched her, taking one last graceful, solo dance around the now empty and clean, church basement. Echoing in my mind, at least, was the voice of Christina Aguilera, singing her 2020 song Beautiful

... I am beautiful no matter what they say

Words can't bring me down

I am beautiful in every single way

Yes, words can't bring me down, oh no

So don't you bring me down today..."

I looked for Willow the next week, and the week after that. I asked Harry about her, but he would only shake his head. I never saw Willow again. But I will always remember her swaying to the music, fully herself, in that shimmering moment of meaning. A song. A soul. Beautiful, still.

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